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E2 Speaking & Listening – Exam Prep Lesson 4: Talking about the past – Lesson plan and answers

Learners finish able to talk for a minute about something that happened, using the past simple, and to ask and answer *Did you…?* and *What did you…?* questions. Assessors listen for a past tense in Tasks 1 and 2.

Materials: Handout E2-4A, one per learner. Topic cards from the handout cut up, one set per pair. A timer.

Activity 1: Yesterday (25 minutes, teacher-led)

1. Draw a line on the board with *yesterday* on the left, *today* in the middle and *tomorrow* on the right. Tell the class five things you did yesterday, pointing left: “I got up at six. I walked to the station. I had a coffee. I taught a class. I watched the news.”
2. Ask what you did. Write the verbs on the board as learners recall them, in two columns: *walked, watched* and *got, had, taught*. Ask what is different. Name the columns *add -ed* and *change the word*.
3. Drill the three sounds of *-ed* with hands on the throat: *walked* and *cooked* end in a t sound; *phoned* and *played* end in a d sound; *wanted* and *visited* add a syllable. Do not teach the rule. Train the ear with six more verbs.
4. Build the list of twelve everyday irregular verbs on the board with the class: *go, have, get, eat, buy, come, see, make, meet, take, do, be*. Say the present; learners call the past.
5. Rub out the past forms one at a time. Point to a verb and a learner; they say a true sentence about yesterday.

Activity 2: Last Saturday (20 minutes)

1. Hand out E2-4A. Learners complete the verb table in section A from memory, then check against the board.
2. Learners complete the gap text in section B alone.
3. Pairs compare, then read the text aloud to each other, a sentence each. Listen for the *-ed* endings.
4. Pairs cover the text and retell the day from the verbs alone.

Activity 3: Did you…? (25 minutes)

1. Board the question: *Did you cook dinner yesterday?* Box *Did* and underline *cook*. Ask why it is not *cooked*. Establish: *did* carries the past, so the verb goes back to its basic form.
2. Drill short answers: *Yes, I did. No, I didn’t.* Then the *wh-* form: *What did you cook? Where did you go? Who did you see?*
3. Learners stand and do the survey in section C. They must find a different person for each line, ask one follow-up question, and write the name and one detail.
4. Feedback: learners report one finding each: “Sara went to the market last week. She bought fish.”
5. Correct on the board the two most common errors you heard, usually *Did you went* and *I go yesterday*.

Activity 4: A one-minute past talk (30 minutes)

1. Remind learners of the talk shape from Lesson 1: start, three things, finish. For a past talk, the three things are in time order.
2. Board the frame from section D: *when, where, who with, what happened, how I felt*.
3. Model a talk on *Last weekend* in about one minute, touching each part of the frame.
4. Learners make five-word notes for the topic *A good day*, one word per part. Two minutes.
5. Pairs: A talks, B times one minute. Swap. Change partners and repeat with a new topic card and no notes.
6. Monitor for verbs slipping into the present. Note examples for the end.

Activity 5: Two questions about the past (20 minutes)

1. Remind learners that after the talk the partner asks two questions. For a past talk, the questions use *did* or *was*.
2. Board four starters: *What did you…? Who did you…? Was it…? Did you like…?*
3. In threes: one speaker, one partner, one observer. The speaker takes a topic card and talks. The partner asks two past questions. The observer counts the past verbs they hear and reports the number.
4. Rotate twice so that everyone speaks.
5. Board five sentences you noted, with errors. The class corrects them. Homework: tell someone at home, in English, about your day.

Answer key, Lesson 4

- **Section A:** went, had, got, bought, met, ate, saw, was / were; walked, cooked, watched, talked, played, visited, phoned, wanted.
- **Section B:** 1 got, 2 had, 3 walked, 4 bought, 5 met, 6 talked, 7 cooked, 8 watched, 9 was.